

# Studies in Literature, Grade 12

University Preparation

ETS4U

This course is for students with a special interest in literature and literary criticism. The course may focus on themes, genres, time periods, or countries. Students will analyse a range of forms and stylistic elements of literary texts and respond personally, critically, and creatively to them. They will also assess critical interpretations, write analytical essays, and complete an independent study project.

**Prerequisite:** English, Grade 11, University Preparation

## Strands

The expectations in this course are organized into a single strand.

# STUDIES IN LITERATURE

## OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Understanding Texts:** read and demonstrate an understanding of a variety of literary texts from different countries, cultures, and historical periods;
- 2. Analysing Texts:** respond to and analyse literary texts to develop and extend their understanding of how content, form, and style in combination communicate meaning and enhance a text's effectiveness;
- 3. Critical Literacy:** demonstrate an understanding that the perspective of the author, the reader, and the text all influence the reading experience;
- 4. Literary Criticism:** use literary criticism to enhance their understanding of literature;
- 5. The Role of Literature in Society:** assess the importance of literature as a social and cultural force.

## SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

### 1. Understanding Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

#### Variety of Texts

- 1.1** read a variety of types of literary texts by authors from a variety of backgrounds, cultures, and time periods (*e.g., create an annotated bibliography of titles they have read on a specific theme, with brief notes about their reactions to each title; design a reading list of self-selected texts, in consultation with the teacher, to explore a particular genre, author, time period, or country; write a literary essay on a particular genre, author, time period, or country, synthesizing information and insights from multiple texts*)

**Teacher prompt:** "Who are the major writers and what are the major texts associated with this literary movement?"

#### Reading With a Purpose

- 1.2** identify a purpose (or purposes) for reading particular texts (*e.g., an essay, to determine the author's beliefs; a literary reference text, to obtain information about an author; a novel, a literary period, or various rhetorical and literary devices; a website, to find biographical information about an author; works by Aboriginal writers, to develop their understanding of some of the cultural and social concerns of First Nation, Métis, or Inuit peoples*)

**Teacher prompt:** "What important details did you notice in rereading the text that you missed in your first reading?"

#### Using Reading Comprehension Strategies

- 1.3** identify a variety of reading comprehension strategies, select those that are most appropriate for specific reading purposes and tasks, and use them before, during, and after reading to enhance their understanding of texts (*e.g., develop a series of questions while reading a text; make connections between a text and other texts, personal experiences, and global or community events; annotate a short excerpt from a play or novel to explain inferences, make connections, record questions and reactions, paraphrase ideas, and interpret graphics*)

**Teacher prompts:** "What insights into the novel did you develop as a result of the journal exchanges with your group members?" "Was your prior knowledge of the topic useful for understanding the situation depicted in the novel? Why or why not?"

### 2. Analysing Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

#### Responding to Texts

- 2.1** respond to texts in a variety of ways before, during, and after reading to extend their understanding of the ideas, themes, language,

and issues in the texts (e.g., collaborate with peers to create dialogue for and enact a scene that represents a different resolution from the one in a story they have read; write in role as a central character who is reflecting upon his or her choices and the possible consequences of each; create a concept map of the figurative allusions in a text to help identify some underlying ideas in the text)

**Teacher prompts:** “What connections were you able to make between the poem you studied in depth and other texts you’ve read in the course?” “What observations did you make about the author’s writing style as you read the story?” “What recurring themes can you identify in this poet’s work? Do you find these themes relevant to your personal experience?”

### Exploring Background Information

**2.2** use information from secondary sources to understand how historical, political, and cultural contexts influence the presentation of ideas, issues, and themes in texts (e.g., conduct research into the historical period in which a novel is set to identify social and economic factors that would have affected the life choices of the novel’s male and female characters; create a web page for other students that summarizes how the historical, political, and social conditions of the time may have influenced the writing of a particular text; identify factors that might influence or explain the behaviour of the characters in a text, such as familial expectations or pressures, faith, attitudes about homosexuality or sexual identity, or attitudes about the supernatural)

**Teacher prompts:** “What historical event has the author depicted in the novel and how has the event been incorporated into the story?” “Is the particular political situation portrayed in the novel of major or minor importance to the theme and/or action in the text?”

### Analysing Texts

**2.3** analyse texts in terms of the information, ideas, issues, and themes they explore, providing evidence from the texts to support their analysis (e.g., identify imagery that communicates a central theme of a text; make inferences about a character’s psychology on the basis of the character’s actions; write a new scene for a play to highlight an aspect of its theme; infer the social class of the characters in a story based on their speech in passages of dialogue; compare the arguments in two essays and write a summary of each author’s thesis/position)

**Teacher prompts:** “What details in the story suggest or reveal the nature of the conflict between the characters?” “How do the poem’s images relate to its theme?” “What new insight is provided by the author’s repetition of this phrase from earlier in the story?” “What evidence in the text supports your inference about the character’s motivation?”

### Text Forms

**2.4** explain how the characteristics of different text forms help communicate meaning in a variety of literary texts (e.g., explain the effect of disruptions in chronological order – such as flashbacks or flash forwards – in a novel; select a scene from a text and rewrite it in a different form – such as by converting an excerpt from a novel into a news report; explain what information the shift from metre to free verse in a poem conveys to the reader; write a parody of a poem)

**Teacher prompts:** “Where is your eye drawn first in the graphic novel – to the illustrations or the text? How does this affect the way you navigate through the text?” “How does the prologue to the play prepare the audience for what follows? By establishing a mood? By provoking curiosity? Or in some other way?” “How effectively does the pre-title sequence in this film version of the play communicate the opening mood of the play?” “What would happen to the novel if its events were related in a different order?”

### Elements of Style

**2.5** identify various elements of style used in texts and explain how they help communicate meaning and enhance the effectiveness of the text (e.g., analyse the syntax of sentences in a paragraph to clarify the meaning of the paragraph, and assess the effect created by the syntax; assess how the use of multiple narrators affects the pacing, tone, and revelation of themes in a novel; view a role play of a scene from a text and assess the clarity and authenticity of the characters’ voices; write an essay tracing the use of a particular image throughout a text and evaluating its effectiveness in conveying the theme of the text; write and deliver a persuasive speech related to an issue in a text, using rhetorical devices similar to those employed in the text)

**Teacher prompts:** “What effect is achieved by the poet’s unusual syntactical constructions?” “What details in the dramatic monologue reveal the speaker’s inner motivations and values most clearly?” “How does the use of an extended metaphor or analogy heighten the impact of the essay’s thesis?”

### 3. Critical Literacy

By the end of this course, students will:

#### The Author's Perspective

- 3.1** demonstrate an understanding of how an author's writing has been influenced by factors such as gender, time period, cultural background, and social and political conditions and events (*e.g., explain in a seminar presentation the ways in which a text reveals the background and interests of its author; use a graphic organizer to compare two texts on the same theme from the same time period by authors of different nationalities or social circumstances, and determine whether and how their different backgrounds may have influenced their points of view*)

**Teacher prompt:** "Do the ideas and views of the author reflect or challenge attitudes that were widely held at the time the text was written? What influences on the author might account for his or her views?"

#### Audience Perspectives

- 3.2** analyse texts in terms of how social, cultural, and political contexts and different readers' personal perspectives may influence readers' interpretations of the text (*e.g., evaluate the message in a play or novel from a past historical period in the light of contemporary social attitudes about gender, race, sexual orientation, social class, and/or ethnicity*)

**Teacher prompts:** "Do contemporary attitudes about gender and sexual orientation in Western cultures make it easier or harder for you to understand the conflict depicted in a novel written before 1900?" "Why might a war poem from a past century have had a different impact on the audience of its day than on audiences from other times, including contemporary audiences?"

#### Perspectives in the Text

- 3.3** analyse texts to identify particular perspectives presented in them and the stylistic and/or structural means used to communicate those perspectives (*e.g., identify whose psychology or perspective(s) is/are foregrounded in a text – those of characters from "mainstream" society or those of characters in a "marginal" position in society; explain how language, imagery, and structure work together in a text to help communicate one or several perspectives; write the script for a scene in which characters discuss a social issue addressed in a text they have read, to express*

*different viewpoints on the issue; create and role-play a dialogue between a "heard" voice and another relevant but "unheard" voice from a text*)

**Teacher prompts:** "Do you think the narrator's opinions are completely unbiased? What evidence in the text suggests that he or she is (or isn't) an entirely reliable commentator?" "Which characters in the story have not been given a voice, and what difference does that make to the way you understand their situation?" "Does this character's response to social conventions match or differ from the dominant perspective(s) in the text? How does it support or contradict the theme?"

### 4. Literary Criticism

By the end of this course, students will:

#### Understanding Literary Concepts and Terms

- 4.1** demonstrate an understanding of key concepts and specialized terms that are used in literary criticism (*e.g., create a poster that uses appropriate terminology to identify the characteristics of particular genres; classify course texts according to the literary movements, genres, or thematic categories they exemplify; list key elements of a critical theory that could be applied to a particular text*)

**Teacher prompts:** "What new concepts have you learned that you find helpful in thinking about literary texts?" "Which literary approach makes the most sense to you? Why?" "How can looking at a text through a specific critical lens shed light on the meaning of the text?"

#### Applying Concepts

- 4.2** use key concepts or approaches of literary criticism to help them analyse and interpret literary texts (*e.g., in a classroom discussion, relate characters in a short story to various archetypes; create a poster presenting interpretations of a text based on two different critical approaches; write a critical review of a text using a particular critical approach and evaluate the usefulness of the approach as an interpretive tool*)

**Teacher prompts:** "How might your interpretation of the text change if you considered it from a feminist perspective?" "What differences would there be between a Marxist and a feminist reading of this text?" "Why is it helpful to apply a number of theories before committing to an interpretation of a text?"

## Researching and Evaluating Critical Interpretations

**4.3** assess critical interpretations found in print and electronic sources and use those that seem most appropriate, helpful, or convincing to extend their understanding of specific works in the course (*e.g., write a brief synopsis of a critical review and assess the degree to which it provides insight into a play; using a graphic organizer, compare different book reviews, including a review they have written, in terms of what issues or aspects of a literary text they focus on*)

**Teacher prompt:** “What does the essayist/reviewer think about the text and what evidence or arguments does he or she use to support the interpretation?”

## Assessing Peer Critical Responses

**4.4** compare peers’ critical responses with their own to clarify and extend their understanding of literary texts (*e.g., record, reflect on, and comment on group members’ responses to a section of a novel; participate in a group discussion about the validity of a critic’s interpretation of a text*)

**Teacher prompt:** “To what extent do you agree with your classmates’ analyses of the text? Which of their interpretations of the novel do you find problematic, and why?”

## 5. The Role of Literature in Society

By the end of this course, students will:

### Fostering Social, Cultural, and Political Awareness

**5.1** explain how literary texts raise awareness about a range of topics, issues, ideas, cultures, events, and people (*e.g., in a presentation to the class, describe how a particular literary text has altered their view of, or provided insight into, a social injustice, a contemporary issue, a cultural or religious conflict, or the legacy of an important historical figure; identify the issues addressed in a controversial literary text and explain how the text challenges social, cultural, or political norms with respect to those issues; identify texts they have studied that bring marginalized voices to the attention of a mainstream audience*)

**Teacher prompts:** “Did the novel offer a valid perspective on the issue that you hadn’t encountered in your research?” “Can you name a literary text that has generated controversy? Why was it controversial? How did the text – or the controversy that surrounded the text – contribute to the public’s understanding of the issues it raised?”

## Engaging the Intellect and Imagination

**5.2** identify ways in which literary texts can promote readers’ intellectual and imaginative growth (*e.g., in a small group discussion, identify ideas in a literary text that cast new light on some aspect of their own lives; explore, in role, the subconscious or conscious motivations of a character in a text; use a teacher-provided prop that suggests the theme of a text as the focus of a short dramatic presentation about the text*)

**Teacher prompt:** “How has a specific author managed to grab your interest and make you think about a particular topic or issue?”

## Promoting Personal and Social Change

**5.3** identify ways in which literary texts might promote social and personal change (*e.g., write and deliver a speech based on a famous example of political rhetoric to encourage an audience to take social action; write a journal entry about ways in which literature has inspired or might inspire people to change their minds or their behaviour; write an editorial, incorporating references from a text, recommending a remedy for an injustice depicted in the text*)

**Teacher prompts:** “How has one text studied in the course prompted you to reconsider your own attitudes or beliefs?” “How has the reading of a specific text helped you to better understand those whose life experiences are significantly different from your own experiences?”

## Exploring Human Nature

**5.4** explain how the study of literature has contributed to their understanding of human nature (*e.g., in a class discussion, debate the validity of quotations about human nature found in texts studied in the course; relate the educational opportunities available to various characters in a novel to the characters’ moral, intellectual, or emotional development in the novel; identify similarities and differences in how myths from around the world portray human motivations and behaviour; identify, and share with the class, text passages that seem to capture or express some truth about human emotions such as loss, joy, pride, regret, or anticipation*)

**Teacher prompts:** “What recurring themes have emerged in this course that would shed light on what it means to be human?” “Is there a specific text that has helped you understand better those whose life experiences are significantly different from your own?”

**Developing Personal Awareness**

**5.5** explain how their study of literature has enhanced their understanding of themselves as readers and as individuals (e.g., *explain in a journal entry how one or more literary texts have influenced their own world view; explain in a letter to a friend how a text has helped them to cope with a difficult situation; describe a life lesson they have learned from a text; share their reflections about the experience of studying literary texts with a group of younger students; in a class discussion, explain how their reading in the course has influenced their appreciation of a particular literary genre or historical period, or a particular author's work*)

**Teacher prompts:** “Which texts most resonate with your own experiences?” “What kinds of texts do you consider yourself most skilled at interpreting?” “Which of the texts that you have read this year did you find most challenging? Why?”